🐾 Apollo & Artemis Training Guide

Diana's 16-Week Plan · Pit Bull × Border Collie · 5 Months Old

Apollo: Reactive/Fearful | Artemis: Confident | PSD Pathway | Force-Free Only

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⚠️ Read This First — The Most Important Section

These rules must be followed by Diana, Luis, AND anyone else who spends time with the dogs. If one person skips these, it undoes all the work everyone else is doing.

🐕🐕 Why Two Sisters Raised Together Is Extra Work

When two puppies grow up together, they can bond more with each other than with you — like two kids who only ever play with each other and never make other friends. Being apart from each other becomes very upsetting, and they start ignoring you during training.

There is also a specific risk with **two female dogs** as they mature. Female-female pairs are more likely to fight seriously than other pairings, especially as they become adults. This does NOT mean it will happen — but it means the rules in this section are essential, not optional.

The good news: **If Diana starts these steps now, Apollo and Artemis can grow up happy, confident, and living peacefully together.**

📋 5 Rules — Start Today

1. **Train them one at a time — always**
   When you train one dog, the other is in a crate or another room. No joint training until Week 13.
2. **Walk them separately at least 3x per week**
   Each dog needs solo walks — just her and you. This builds confidence and independence from her sister.
3. **Each dog sleeps in her own crate**
   Put crates in different spots sometimes so they practice not always being right next to each other.
4. **Give each dog 10–15 minutes alone with you every day**
   Just you and one dog — no sister around. Play, train, cuddle. Without this, they bond more with each other than with you.
5. **Always feed them in separate spots**
   Never let them eat near each other's food. Separate bowls, separate areas, every single time.

⚠️ If the dogs begin fighting with each other, or are extremely distressed when apart, contact a certified trainer (CPDT-KA) or vet right away. Don't wait.

🧬 Meet Apollo & Artemis

🧬 What Kind of Dogs Are They?

They are a Pit Bull and Border Collie mix — two breeds built for hard work all day long. That means a LOT of energy and a LOT of brainpower. They need to use both, or they get into trouble.

Intelligence 10/10 Will find workarounds if Diana isn't consistent.	**Energy** 10/10 Needs 1.5–2 hours of real activity every day.
Chase Drive 8/10 Will chase kids, cats, squirrels. Normal for this mix.	**Strength** 8/10 50–70 lbs as adults. Leash work starts now.
Sensitivity 9/10 Yelling or harsh corrections makes them worse.	**Trainability** 10/10 With treats and kindness, they can learn almost anything.

🐾 Each Dog's Personality

Apollo is the **fearful, reactive one.** She barks or panics when something frightens her. This is fear — not aggression. She needs extra patience, a slower pace, and a gentler approach. See the Apollo section for her specific plan.

Artemis is the **confident, calmer one.** She is the stronger candidate for service dog training. She still needs all the same foundation work — she just handles new experiences a little more easily.

📅 What's Normal at 5 Months Old

- **Short attention span.** They can focus for 5–10 minutes at a time. Short, fun sessions beat long ones every time.
- **Cap exercise at 25 minutes per session.** Bones are still growing. Too much running or jumping can cause joint damage.
- **Chewing is normal.** Teeth are still coming in. Give them safe things to chew before they find the wrong things.
- **Apollo may get more fearful for a while.** Puppies go through fear stages between 6 and 14 months. Be extra patient during this window.
- **Full maturity is 18–24 months away.** Their brains literally cannot control impulses yet. Crates and gates are not cruel — they are necessary.

🛠️ Equipment List

No choke collars, prong collars, or shock collars. These dogs are sensitive. Aversive tools can make a fearful dog significantly worse.

🏠 Crates — Need 2

- Wire crates, 42 inches — they'll grow into them.
- Cover 3 sides with a blanket to create a den feel.
- One crate per dog, always. Never share.
- Occasionally put crates in different spots to practice being apart.

🦮 Harnesses — Need 2

- **Front-clip harness** for each dog. Good options: Ruffwear Front Range or Julius-K9. The front clip redirects pulling without causing pain.
- Should fit snug — two fingers under any strap.
- Two standard 6-foot leashes. No retractable leashes.
- One long leash (15–30 feet) for recall practice in the yard.

🍗 Training Treats

High-value (for new skills or hard moments): small bits of boiled chicken, hot dog, cheese, or freeze-dried liver.

Everyday rewards: regular kibble or soft treats like Zuke's Mini Naturals.

Wear a treat pouch on your hip every training session. Treats should be pea-sized or smaller — they'll get a lot of them.

🔧 Other Essentials

- **Baby gates (at least 2).** Separate dogs without locking them in a crate.
- **Puzzle feeders and snuffle mats.** Mental work tires them out just like running does.
- **Frozen Kongs.** Stuff with peanut butter or wet food, freeze overnight. Give to the waiting dog in her crate to keep her calm.
- **Clicker (optional).** Click the exact moment the dog does something right, then treat. One click = one treat, every time.

🛡️ For Apollo Specifically

- Yellow bandana or vest that reads "NERVOUS" — signals strangers to give her space.
- Thundershirt (snug wrap) can help during scary moments.
- Adaptil collar or plug-in diffuser — calming pheromone product that helps some fearful dogs.
- Ask your vet about calming supplements (L-theanine) or anxiety medication. This is not giving up — it's giving the training a better chance to work.

📅 Daily Routine

⚠️ Luis should handle at least one session per day. Both Diana and Luis must use the exact same words and the same rules. "Down" and "lie down" confuse dogs who are still learning.

📅 Sample Daily Schedule

7:00 AM
Morning

- Both dogs outside to potty — on leash
- Feed in separate spots
- Train Artemis 10 min while Apollo is crated; then swap

8:30 AM
Walk

- Walk ONE dog solo for 20–25 minutes
- Other dog stays with a frozen Kong in her crate — built-in separation practice

10:00 AM
Brain Work

- Puzzle feeder or snuffle mat — one dog at a time
- Chew time with a bully stick or frozen Kong in their crates

12:00 PM
Midday

- Potty break — supervised yard time together is OK
- Quick 5-minute training check-in for each dog
- Nap in crates — puppies need 14–16 hours of sleep per day

4:00 PM
Afternoon

- Second walk — solo or together depending on the day
- 10-minute training session for each dog
- Active play: fetch, tug, flirt pole — one at a time

6:00 PM
Evening

- Dinner — always in separate spots
- Calm time: licki mat or frozen Kong
- Practice touching paws, ears, and mouth — builds handling tolerance

8:30 PM
Bedtime

- Last potty trip
- Each dog into her crate with something to chew
- Lights out by 9–10 PM — sleep dramatically improves behavior

⏱️ Training Session Rules

- **5–10 minutes per session.** Stop before they get bored, not after.
- **Always end on a win** — make the last thing easy if needed.
- **Two short sessions beats one long one**, every time.
- Don't train a dog that's overstimulated, too hungry, or just finished running.
- If it's going badly — stop, take a breath, start over with something simple.

1️⃣ Phase 1: Weeks 1–4 — Building the Foundation

Don't try to teach too much right now. The goal is structure, bonding with Diana, and getting separation practice underway.

Week 1 — Names · Crates · Alone Time

Goal: Each dog looks at Diana when she says her name. Both enter crates willingly. Separation practice begins.

- Both Name game: say the dog's name → when she looks → "yes!" + treat. 20 reps, 3x daily, each dog alone.
- Both Crate practice: toss a treat in → let her walk in and out freely. Never push her in or shut the door suddenly.
- Both Separation start: one dog in crate with a frozen Kong, train the other for 10 minutes.
- Both Handling: gently touch paws, ears, and mouth every day. Treat after. Normalizes being handled.
- Both Big praise every time they go potty outside.

Week 2 — Sit · Leave It · Self-Control

Goal: Both dogs sit when Diana stops moving. They understand "leave it" with easy items. 20+ minutes apart without distress.

- Both Sit: hold treat at nose, move it back over her head → bottom goes down → "yes!" + treat. After a few days, say "sit" before luring.
- Both Leave it (easy): treat in closed fist → when she stops trying → open OTHER hand and give treat from that one.
- Both Mat practice: give a treat every time she steps on a bath mat. This becomes "place" later.
- Both Let them drag a leash indoors (supervised) to get comfortable with how it feels.

Week 3 — Down · Stay · Watch Me

Goal: Both dogs lie down on command. Can hold sit or down for 5 seconds. Will make eye contact on cue.

- Both Down: from a sit, slowly move treat from nose to the floor between her paws → elbows touch the floor → "yes!" + treat.
- Both "Watch me": hold treat near your eyes → the second she looks at your eyes → "yes!" + treat. Build to 3 seconds of eye contact.
- Both Stay: ask for sit or down → one tiny step back → return → treat. Seconds and inches at a time.
- Both Leash intro: use front-clip harness. Leash goes tight → stop walking. Leash goes loose → keep walking.
- Both Door rule starts: dog must sit before going through any door. Every door, every time.

Week 4 — Come · Biting · Chewing

Goal: Dogs come when called from 10 feet. Biting on skin is decreasing. They have safe things to chew.

- Both "Come": long leash in yard → name + "come" → back up fast as you call → huge treat party when she arrives.
- Both Biting: teeth touch skin → "ouch!" loudly → turn away and ignore for 30 seconds. Be consistent every single time.
- Both Rotate 4–5 safe chews every 2–3 days. Give one BEFORE they start chewing wrong things.
- Both Take each dog on her own adventure once this week — a car ride, a new street, a pet store. One dog at a time.

✅ You're on track if: Both dogs look up when you say their names. Both walk into their crates happily. Both can be alone for 30 minutes without crying or destroying things.

2️⃣ Phase 2: Weeks 5–10 — Real Skills

Now that structure is in place, we build the real commands. Apollo gets a gentler version of most things. Artemis begins service dog foundation work.

Weeks 5–6 — **Loose Leash Walking · Stronger "Come"**

Goal: Leash stays loose for most of the walk. "Come" works from 20 feet with small distractions.

- Both Leash tight → stop. Don't pull back. Wait. Leash loose → "yes!" and keep going.
- Both Say "let's go" when you start walking. Give a treat every 10–20 steps when the leash is loose.
- Both Direction changes: say her name → turn the other way → treat when she follows. Keeps her focused on you.
- Both "Come" games: one person holds the dog, other calls from far away. Run backwards as you call. Big party when she arrives.
- Apollo Keep walks in quiet areas for now. See the Apollo section for her modified leash plan.

Weeks 7–8 — **Stay · Wait · No Jumping**

Goal: 30-second stay at 6 feet. Dogs wait before meals and at doors. Jumping drops significantly.

- Both Stay: build to 30 seconds, then 6 feet of distance. Change only ONE variable at a time — either duration OR distance.
- Both Wait at the food bowl: sit → put bowl down → "OK" to release. Break the sit? Pick the bowl back up and try again.
- Both Jumping: turn your back, cross arms, zero reaction. The second four paws hit the floor → spin around, treat immediately.
- Artemis "Touch": teach her to tap her nose to your open palm on cue. A useful service dog foundation skill.

Weeks 9–10 — **"Place" · Greeting People · Real World Practice**

Goal: Dog goes to mat on command and holds it 2 minutes. Greets visitors calmly. Skills work in different environments.

- Both "Place": point to mat and say "place." Treat for going to it. Build to 2-minute holds.
- Both Visitor rule: brief all guests before arrival — no attention until four paws are on the floor.
- Both Practice in different locations: yard, kitchen, front porch, park. A dog that only listens at home hasn't really learned it.
- Both "It's Yer Choice" game: treats in open palm → dog that waits without grabbing gets the treat. Builds impulse control.

3️⃣ Phase 3: Weeks 11–16 — The Real World

A dog that listens at home but not in public hasn't fully learned yet. This phase takes the training into real environments.

Weeks 11–12 — **Out in the World**

Goal: Commands work in public, around distractions, and with all household adults.

- Both Practice at pet stores, parking lots, parks, and outdoor cafés.
- Both Luis and other household adults should give commands too — dogs need to listen to everyone, not just Diana.
- Artemis Begin calm exposure to other dogs at a distance. Reward calm behavior when she notices another dog.
- Apollo Follow the Apollo section plan for all public outings. Always stay below her reaction threshold.

Weeks 13–14 — **Training Together — Carefully**

Goal: Both dogs can follow commands in the same space with two handlers.

- Both Diana works Apollo, Luis works Artemis — same yard, start far apart. Slowly decrease distance over several days.
- Both Practice walking past each other — two people, two dogs. Treat for loose leash and calm behavior.
- Both "Place" at the same time — each dog to her own mat in the same room.
- Keep doing individual solo sessions. Group work does not replace individual training.

Weeks 15–16 — **Final Check + Next Steps**

Goal: Strong manners at home and in public. Apollo more stable. Artemis showing PSD readiness.

- Both Doorbell rings → both dogs go to their "place" mats. Practice separately first, then together.
- Both Walk side by side with two handlers on loose leashes.
- Artemis Assessment: Is she focused on Diana? Does she bounce back from surprises? Stays calm in public? If yes — ready for PSD foundation work.
- Apollo Honest check: Is she less reactive than 3 months ago? If not improving — bring in a professional trainer or vet behaviorist.
- Both Sign up for a group obedience class for real-world socialization and practice.

🎯 Fixing Problem Behaviors

🦷 Jumping & Biting

Why they do it: Normal puppy behavior. Teeth are still coming in. Jumping happens because it accidentally gets rewarded with attention.

1. **Zero reaction to jumping or biting**
   The second teeth touch skin or paws hit a person: turn back, cross arms, look up, walk away. No words, no eye contact, 30 seconds of being ignored.

2. **Four paws on floor = attention**
   The moment all four paws land: spin around, get happy, give a treat. Within 2 seconds. Timing is everything.

3. **Redirect biting to a toy immediately**
   Keep a tug toy nearby. Teeth on skin → pull out toy. Teeth on toy → play begins. Teeth on skin → play stops. Every time.

4. **End play before it escalates**
   Most biting happens when the dog is too excited. Stop the game before the biting starts. Ask for a "settle" and reward calm.

⚠️ If anyone in the house lets them jump "just this once" — it breaks the training for everyone. 100% consistent from every person.

🦮 Leash Pulling

Why they do it: Because it worked before. If pulling gets them where they want to go, they keep doing it.

1. **Get the right equipment first**
   Front-clip harness every walk. Redirects the pull sideways instead of forward — a significant difference.

2. **Stop every time the leash gets tight**
   Don't pull back. Just stop. Wait until the leash goes loose, then say "yes!" and keep going. Pulling = you stop.

3. **Reward loose-leash walking frequently**
   Every 10–20 steps of nice walking: "good girl" and a treat. Catch her doing it right.

4. **Change direction often**
   Randomly turn and walk the other way. Say her name first. Treat when she follows. Keeps her eyes on you.

💡 Walks will be short and slow at first. A 15-minute walk with a loose leash is better than a 45-minute pulling battle.

📣 "Come" — The Most Critical Command

A solid "come" can save their lives. Protect the word — never let it lose its meaning.

1. **Never call them for something unpleasant**
   Don't call "come" for nail trims, baths, or ending fun. Go to them for those things. "Come" must always predict something wonderful.

2. **Make it the best thing that ever happened**
   When they come: throw a party. Multiple treats, big happy voice, get down on their level. Every single time while learning.

3. **Always use the long leash outside**
   Never practice "come" off-leash in an unfenced area until the recall is completely reliable.

4. **Say it once**
   Name + "come" — once. If she doesn't move, run the other way and make yourself exciting. Repeating it teaches the word means nothing.

🦴 Destructive Chewing

1. **Put wrong things away**
   Shoes in closets. Cords covered. Chargers hidden. Don't leave things out and expect them not to chew them.

2. **Rotate 4–6 safe chews**
   Swap them every 2–3 days to keep them interesting. Bully sticks, frozen Kongs, Nylabones, marrow bones, antlers.

3. **Redirect, don't scold**
   Calmly say "ah-ah" → take it away → hand her a correct chew right away → praise when she takes it.

4. **More brain work = less chewing**
   A bored dog destroys things. Puzzle feeders and frozen Kongs mean her brain is too busy to eat the furniture.

🛡️ Apollo: Reactivity Plan

Apollo is not being bad. She is scared. Punishing her for fear makes things significantly worse and increases the risk of biting. The only thing that works is teaching her the scary thing predicts good food.

🧠 Why Apollo Reacts the Way She Does

When something scares Apollo, her body goes into panic mode. She barks, lunges, or tries to escape because it works — the scary thing goes away. So she keeps doing it.

The fix is to change what the scary thing means. Every time Apollo sees something scary and stays below her reaction threshold: she gets amazing chicken. Over time, "scary thing" starts to mean "great food is coming" instead of "danger."

📋 Step 1: Build Her Trigger List

Write down everything that makes Apollo react. Next to each, write how close it has to be before she reacts. Example:

- Stranger walking by at 30 feet: stiff body, hard stare
- Stranger at 10 feet: barking and pulling
- Another dog at a distance: freeze and stare
- Loud cars: cowers or bolts
- Kids running: barks

The **distance where she first notices but doesn't react yet** — that is where all her desensitization training happens. If she's already barking, you're too close.

🔄 The Desensitization Steps

1. **Find the right distance**
   Far enough away that Apollo notices the trigger but doesn't bark or lunge. Ears up, slight stiffening — that's OK. Barking means you're too close.

2. **Trigger appears → chicken appears**
   The moment Apollo looks at the trigger: start feeding high-value treats, fast and continuously. Don't wait for her to react. Feed while she's still calm.

3. **Trigger leaves → treats stop**
   When the scary thing is gone, treats stop. This teaches her: that thing makes food appear. Without it, no food. She will begin to want to see it.

4. **Get closer — very, very slowly**
   Once she's calm at 30 feet, try 28 feet in the next session — not the same session. Slow progress holds. Fast progress falls apart.

5. **Never force her toward the trigger**
   Do NOT push her toward scary things to "get her used to it." Do NOT let strangers rush up to pet her. If she's reacting, you went too fast. Back up.

🏠 At Home with Apollo

- Apollo does NOT have to greet guests. Give her a safe retreat — crate with frozen Kong — and let her come out when SHE chooses.
- Tell kids who visit: no running at Apollo, no reaching over her head, no screaming near her. Let her sniff them from a distance first.
- If Artemis's excitement is escalating Apollo's fear — separate them during high-stress moments.
- Keep a simple log: what happened, how close the trigger was, how bad the reaction on a scale of 1–5. You'll see progress that's invisible day to day.

🏥 When to Bring in a Professional

Get help right away if:

- Apollo has snapped at or bitten anyone
- Her reactions are not improving after 6–8 weeks of consistent work
- She is in a state of near-constant panic, not just in specific situations

Look for a trainer with **CPDT-KA** credentials, or ask the vet for a referral to a veterinary behaviorist. Anxiety medication is not giving up — it gives the behavior modification a much better chance to work.

⭐ Artemis: Psychiatric Service Dog Pathway

⚠️ Service dog training is a 2+ year commitment. This section is a starting point only. Work with a professional PSD trainer for the full pathway.

⭐ Why Artemis — And When to Decide

Because Apollo is fearful and reactive, **Artemis is the better candidate for service work right now.** But don't make a final decision until they are 12–18 months old and their adult personalities are established.

Signs Artemis may be a good PSD candidate:

- She focuses on Diana specifically — not just on food or other dogs
- When startled, she bounces back quickly instead of staying upset
- She can maintain focus even with distractions nearby
- She stays calm in new places around new sounds and people
- She tolerates handling of her paws, ears, and face without distress
- Her energy is steady and focused, not frantic

ℹ️ On spaying: Current research suggests waiting until 18–24 months before spaying large-breed dogs. This may benefit brain and body development for working dogs. Discuss timing with a vet experienced with service animals.

🏗️ Foundation Skills — Build First

These are not tasks yet. They are the skills every task is built on. Artemis must master all of these before task training begins.

Sustained focus on Diana

Holds eye contact with Diana for 30–60 seconds in the presence of distractions. Starts with "watch me."

Settle on cue

Lies quietly at Diana's feet for extended periods — in a restaurant, waiting room, or store.

"Under"

Lies calmly under a chair or table on command. Required for most indoor public access work.

Leave food on the floor

"Leave it" must work reliably with food on the ground in a public place. This is a public access requirement.

Neutrality around strangers

Does not bark at, pull toward, or solicit attention from strangers. Not scared. Not excited. Neutral.

Reliable public manners

All leash, sit, stay, and place skills from this guide — working consistently outside in real environments.

🎯 PSD Task Examples

The right tasks depend on Diana's specific diagnosis and needs. Examples of common PSD tasks:

- **Deep Pressure Therapy (DPT):** Artemis lies across Diana's lap or chest on cue. The weight and warmth helps regulate anxiety and panic.
- **Interruption:** Artemis nudges or taps Diana during dissociation, flashbacks, or repetitive behaviors.
- **Room check:** Artemis clears a room before Diana enters — useful for hypervigilance and PTSD symptoms.
- **Grounding:** Artemis presses against Diana during a crisis and remains in contact until released.
- **Medication reminder:** Artemis alerts at a specific time each day, trained using an alarm.

💡 In the US, service dogs do not need official certification — but the dog must be reliably trained and the handler must have a qualifying disability. Keep a detailed training log as documentation.

🏠 House Rules for Everyone

🚨 Inconsistency is the #1 reason dog training fails. Apollo and Artemis are smart enough to learn different rules for different people — and they will, if given the opportunity.

📋 Non-Negotiable Rules

1. **No jumping — from anyone, ever**
   Turn back, cross arms, look up. No exceptions. Not "just this once." Not even when it's cute.
2. **Same words for every command**
   "Sit" means sit. Not "sit down" or "sit, sit, sit." Write commands on a sticky note and put it on the fridge.
3. **No food from the table**
   Ignore begging completely or send to "place." Anyone who feeds from the table creates a problem for everyone.
4. **Make them earn everything**
   Before every meal, walk, toy, or cuddle session — ask for a sit or down. Takes 3 seconds. Builds good habits all day.
5. **Crates are safe spaces, not punishment**
   Never put a dog in a crate when angry. If someone is frustrated, walk away — don't take it out on the dog.
6. **Dogs wait at every door**
   No dog runs through a door without being released. Every door, every time. Prevents bolting and builds impulse control.
7. **Children and dogs are always supervised**
   With these breeds at this age, children and dogs are never left alone together. Not even for 30 seconds.

👤 Luis's Role

- At least one training session per day. Dogs that only listen to one person are a liability.
- At least one solo walk per week with each dog. Builds his bond with them and gives Diana rest.
- Same commands, same rules as Diana — no exceptions.
- If Artemis becomes Diana's service dog, Luis's consistency with the training program is especially important. A service dog confused by inconsistent rules from different people cannot do her job.

👥 Visitor Instructions — Share or Print This

Hi! Diana's dogs Apollo and Artemis are in training. Please follow these rules when you visit:

- When you arrive: ignore both dogs completely. No talking to them, no eye contact, no reaching out.
- Let them sniff you. Don't reach over their heads to pet them.
- Only give attention when all four paws are on the floor.
- Don't give them any food without asking Diana first.
- If a dog jumps on you: turn your back and ignore completely.
- Don't try to pet Apollo (the shy one) — let her approach you on her own terms.
- Kids: no running straight at the dogs. No screaming near them. Don't take their toys or chews.

Thank you — it makes a real difference. 🐾

📊 Tracking Progress

Even 2–3 sentences in a notes app each day adds up. For each dog, write:

- What you practiced
- What went well
- Anything that happened — good or bad

For the service dog pathway, training records matter. Short videos on your phone every few days are worth more than written notes — they show progress that's invisible day to day.

💡 Celebrate small wins. Apollo looked at a stranger without barking? That's huge. Artemis held a stay at the park? That's real progress. Write it down. It's working even when it doesn't feel like it.